Supporting SEMH Pupils:
Understanding the communicative Functions of Behaviour

Dr Scott I-Patrick

Educational Psychologist

High-Wycombe Area Hub

SEMH and Challenging Behaviour

SEMH refers to the social, emotional, and mental well-being of children and young people.

Challenging behaviour in pupils is closely linked to SEMH.

Every challenging behaviour serves an underlying need that even the pupil might not be able to explain.

Effective solutions for supporting pupils hinge on the quality of the relationship between the teacher and pupils.

Teachers need to be aware of the impact of context on pupils' behaviour.

Adapting and differentiating the curriculum content effectively can support pupils who exhibit challenging behaviour.

Uncovering the Underlying Needs

Every challenging behaviour serves an underlying need that even the pupil might not be able to explain.

Understanding the communicative functions of behaviour is crucial to addressing challenging behaviour.

Teachers need to identify the underlying needs that drive challenging behaviour to support pupils effectively.

The Importance of Teacher-Pupil Relationships

Building trust and understanding pupils' strengths and weaknesses is crucial to supporting pupils effectively.

Effective solutions for supporting pupils hinge on the quality of the relationship between the teacher and pupils.

Positive relationships can prevent challenging behaviour and improve pupils' academic outcomes.

Maximizing Positive Affect, Minimizing Negative Affects

The central executive concept states that we are innately programmed to:

→ maximize positive affect,

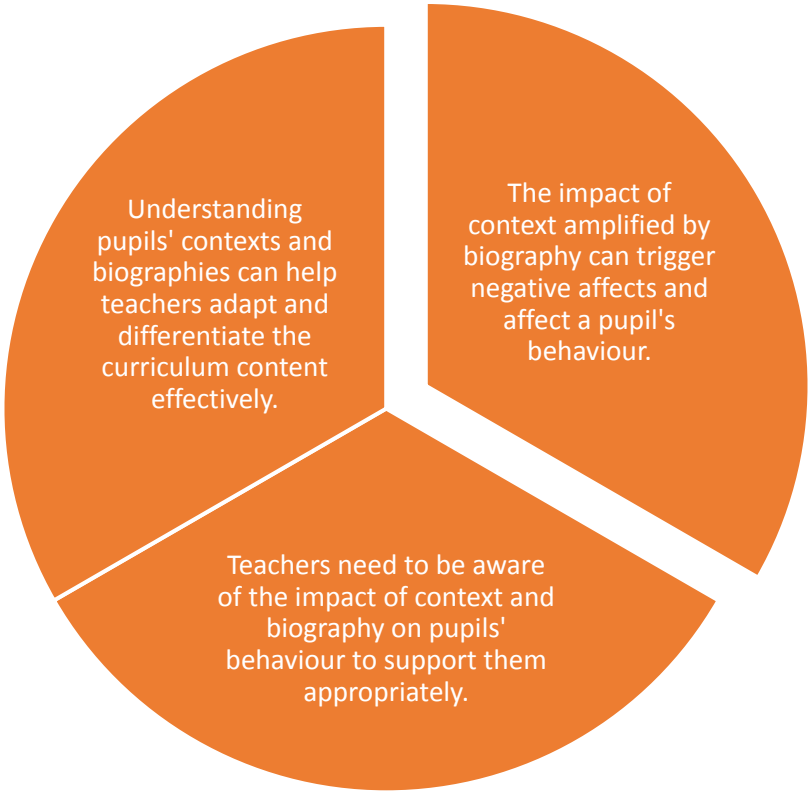
→ minimize negative affects, and

→ minimize the inhibition of affect.

→ A pupil's ability to function effectively is dependent on these factors being in place.

→ Understanding the impact of context on pupils' behaviour and supporting them appropriately can help promote positive affect and minimize negative affects.

The Role of Context and Biography in Pupil Behaviour



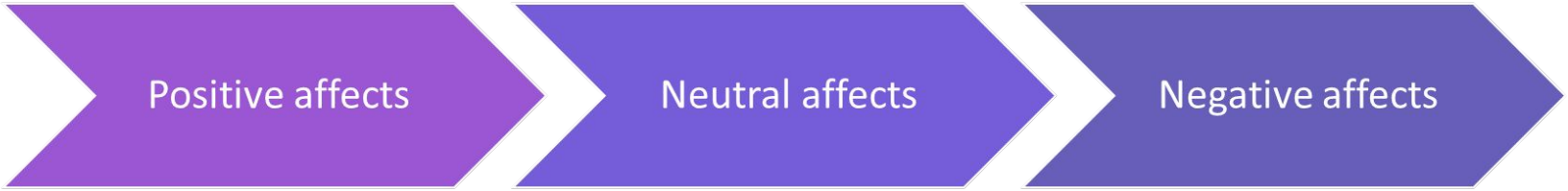
Decoding Behavioural Messages

Challenging behaviour is often a symptom of underlying emotions that pupils might not be able to express effectively.

Understanding the underlying emotions behind challenging behaviour is crucial to addressing it effectively.

Teachers can address challenging behaviour by providing appropriate support, building positive relationships, and adapting and differentiating the curriculum content.

Theory of Affect Script

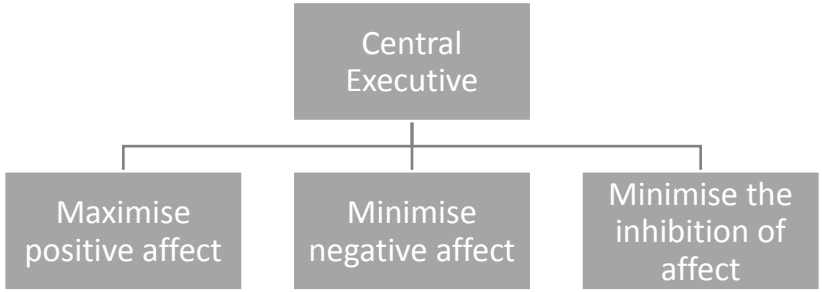


- Interests- Excitement
- Enjoyment-Joy

- Surprise- Startle

- Distress-Anguish
- Fear-Terror
- Anger-Rage
- Shame-Humiliation
- Disgust
- Dismell

The Central Executive



- Silvan Tomkins - 9 innate affects hard-wired into our autonomic nervous system from birth.
- We have no control over these and they are triggered by stimulus in our environment and/or thoughts.

Compass of Shame Scripts

How Do We Resolve Uncomfortable Feelings

The Compass of Shame

Adapted from D.L. Nathanson, Shame and Pride, 1992

Withdrawal:
- isolating oneself
- running and hiding

Attack Other:
- 'turning the tables'
- blaming the victim
- lashing out verbally or physically

Attack Self:
- self put-down
- masochism

Avoidance:
- denial
- abusing drugs and alcohol
- distraction through thrill seeking

Tailoring Education to Pupil Needs

1

Adapting and differentiating the curriculum content based on pupils' strengths and weaknesses is crucial to supporting their success.

2

Understanding pupils' strengths and weaknesses can help teachers adapt and differentiate the curriculum content effectively.

3

Adapting and differentiating the curriculum content can help prevent challenging behaviour and promote positive academic outcomes.

Supporting pupils and practical advice

There are many strategies for supporting pupils with social, emotional, and mental health challenges.

Individually, strategies such as counselling, mentoring and pastoral care can be effective in helping pupils to identify and manage their presenting behaviours.

As a whole school, approaches such as positive behaviour support and restorative justice can be effective in creating a safe and supportive environment for pupils.

Thanks for listening